

arcade ■ games

without risks, as the developers behind the role-playing game, *Torn*, found out.

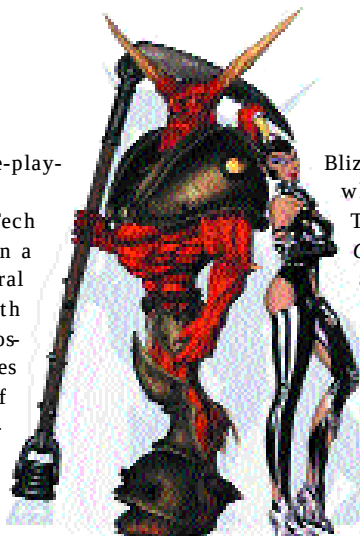
Black Isle Studios (BIS) had licensed the LithTech engine to power their ride to fame. It was then a solution undergoing birthing pains since several versions of the engine were being released with alarming frequency and BIS had a hard time choosing one version and sticking to it. Version changes at this stage of growth often force relearning of tools and this of course played havoc with timelines and the development cycle. The studio also faced technical difficulties while implementing a suitable path-finding algorithm and a flexible camera system, causing further slippage in the likely release date of the game. "Pathfinding was a huge, huge problem. We had a programmer working on pathfinding for probably four months, and it never really worked the way we wanted. It got better, but it never worked well, which consistently killed the morale of the team. They could usually break the pathfinding within a few minutes of getting a new build," explains Feargus Urquhart, director at BIS in a Gamespot.com interview. What did not help were the financial woes that Black Isles' parent company, Interplay, was experiencing. A re-evaluation of the game project followed and *Torn* was scrapped.

Would you like some franchise with that?

Killing a game in its infancy, rather than letting it grow into something that a studio would not be proud of is quite justified. The big names in the gaming industry are built on franchises and are more comfortable dumping a product that might adversely stain a best-selling series.

3D Realms shot down *Prey* because they thought it was not up to their standards. So was the case with Maxis' *Simsville*. The game was designed to offer an experience somewhere between *The Sims* and *SimCity*. It was to retain some of the voyeurism of *The Sims* with more of the planning of *SimCity* along with some adult content in the form of crime, liquor stores and general seediness. Maybe the producers of the game thought that the direction in which the game was headed would have had a negative impact on this hottest of franchises (*The Sims* is the largest selling game on the personal computer) and the game was cancelled after more than two years into the development cycle. A spokesperson for Maxis stated that the game "wasn't up to the standards of the company, despite which, the team did a great job and is being reassigned to other products like *The Sims Online* and other future projects."

Not living up to the mark also saw the demise of a Blizzard title. After the success of *Warcraft II*,



NOT FOR KEEPS: *Dungeon Keeper 3* was shelved, as developers Bullfrog shifted their focus to the consoles

Blizzard North decided to release an adventure which would delve deeper into the Azeroth universe. The game was titled *Warcraft Adventures: Lord of the Clans*. After over a year of development, which included a whole lot of animation work completed and a good amount of voice acting done, Blizzard realised that the game quality was not up to standards and the product was shelved.

Bill Roper, producer of the game puts it "I think the fatal flaw in the project was that we were a little too nostalgic. We definitely included a lot of very strong things from classic adventure games, like strong characters, a compelling storyline, excellent vocalisation and acting, and interesting, fun puzzles that tied into the storyline. I think that by that point we had already fallen behind a certain technology curve. When the game came out, I think people would have bought it, but I think they would have said, 'this is really fun, but this would have been great a couple of years ago'. And so it was an incredibly tough decision. But

I knew that it wasn't going to meet the expectations of anybody here and certainly not the expectation of our fans."

The work that the company did on the adventure game was not completely wasted though, some of the background art and characters found their way into the hugely successful sequel, the real strategy game, *Warcraft III*.

Symptoms of a Dying Game

A rule of thumb

When the developers of a game keep gushing, "...it's too good to be true!", it probably is.

Will it be done?

The developers have been chanting, "When it's done!" for the past three years.

Engine jumping

There is no game engine in the industry that the developers haven't tried.

Frequent changes in staff members

Most of the original development team of the game has quit and now posts flaming messages on the game's Web site.

Public assistance

The Web site of the game encourages you to make generous donations to the 'Save the Developer' fund.

The vanishing act

The developer Web cam has 'Out to Lunch' for the past six months.

The parting shot

Besides all the fun and party, game development is big business and involves huge risks and heartaches—the industry moves at a frantic pace that blurs everything in sight, making even the near future unforeseeable. There are many things that can go wrong during the development of a game, a sad fact that adds credence to the industry joke 'behind every successful game is a game that did not make it'. What was once a good idea to execute two years ago might not be as good today. If developers push their out-dated titles simply because they have hyped it, not only will the games end up holding coffee mugs, but they also risk scarring the developer's reputation. We can thus find some solace in the fact that it is better to have witnessed the production of a promising game, rather than watch the game grow into a mass of bug-ridden bad design decisions.

After all, which is the better of two evils—a developer that releases a sub-par product that empties your pockets and then sends you scurrying after patches, or a developer that you with hype and then pulls the plug on a product that had you craving for it? ■

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